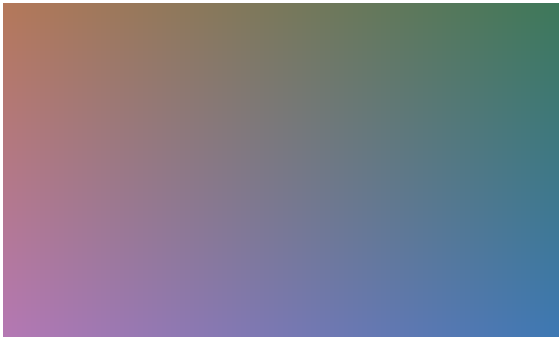


The Long Road North

The road north climbs out of the valley before dawn.
Trucks pass in convoys, headlights cutting the fog.
By mid-morning the pass is a ribbon above the clouds.
Everything that travels this route is counted twice.
The convoy halts for the border check at noon.



Soldiers wave the drivers
through without ceremony.
The paperwork travels ahead,
by fax, to the next post.

By evening the column reaches the northern plain.
The drivers sleep in the cab, engines idling.
Dawn brings the same road, in reverse.